
WHEN APPLYING ONLINE IS NOT WORKING

The conference play

I sent more than fifty applications trying to leave my engineering job. I lost count somewhere after that. Not one cold application produced a phone call. Not one cold email got a reply. I genuinely believed nobody was reading my resume, and looking back I think that was close to true.

The job I eventually got came from one conversation at one conference, with a person I was not supposed to be standing in front of.

I have run this play twice, about ten years apart. The first time was at university career fairs, where I brought a working app on my phone instead of a resume. The second was the conference that got me the job I have now. Both times the mechanism was identical: stop competing on the document, start handing somebody something real.

This is what I actually did. It is not a formula and I want to be honest about that up front. It worked because of what I said when I got there, and the getting there was the cheap part.

1 Bring something they can hold

This is the part almost nobody does, and it is the one I would keep if I could only keep one.

At career fairs in college I built an app on my phone called Medical Reminder. Every other student in that line handed over a piece of paper. I handed over a working thing and let the recruiter hold it. Nobody else was doing that, and it is what guaranteed me interviews.

EXAMPLE

Build the smallest real version of something and put it on your phone. It does not need to be finished, it needs to be touchable. A live prototype, a dashboard you made, a teardown you wrote. Something that exists.

WHY THIS MATTERS: a resume asks somebody to imagine what you can do. A working thing removes the imagining. That difference is worth more than any bullet point you could add.

2 Open with their problem, not your background

The pitch I used at those fairs never started with me.

It started with a question they had personally lived: have you ever left the doctor and been told to remember something for a surgery next week? Doctors have bad handwriting, the instructions are unclear, and you are supposed to keep track of it anyway. So I built an app that takes the doctor's report and sends it back to you as a reminder. At 5pm the night before, it tells you not to eat, because your colonoscopy is tomorrow.

By the time I finished, they were not evaluating a student. They were thinking about their own last hospital visit.

EXAMPLE

Write your opener as a question the listener has felt. Then the friction, plainly. Then what you built, in one sentence. Then one concrete example that makes it real.

WHY THIS MATTERS: nobody at a careers event is short of people talking about themselves. Leading with a problem they recognize is the cheapest way to be the only one who did.

3 Go when you cannot afford to go

Years later, the ticket was around five hundred dollars and I did not have it. I was in a low place, I had just been told by my manager's manager to stop complaining and do my job, and I did not want to go at all.

I found a discount code, got it at a subsidised rate, and forced myself.

EXAMPLE

Before you decide you cannot afford an event, spend twenty minutes looking for a student rate, a diversity scholarship, a community discount code, or a volunteer place. Most large tech conferences have at least two of those and almost nobody looks.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the entire outcome traces back to a decision I nearly made the other way, for a reason that turned out to be solvable in twenty minutes.

4 Go in with one rule, not a plan

I did not have a strategy. I had a sentence: I have nothing to lose, so talk to every single person I can.

That is a lower bar than networking, and it is more useful, because it removes the part where you stand near a group and decide you are not senior enough to join it.

EXAMPLE

Set a number instead of a goal. Twenty conversations. Do not qualify them, do not decide in advance which ones matter, just get to twenty.

WHY THIS MATTERS: you cannot tell which conversation is the one. The one that changed my career started with me not knowing who I was talking to.

5 Get into the room you were not invited to

There was a Microsoft lounge event on a boat. Invite only. I was not invited.

We walked over, watched people boarding, and worked out that entry was by raffle ticket. So I asked people, one after another, whether I could have their ticket once they had used it, so I could walk in behind them.

Someone said yes.

EXAMPLE

When you hit a closed door, spend five minutes working out what the actual gate is before you accept it. A list, a wristband, a ticket, a badge color. Gates are almost always specific, and specific things can be asked for.

WHY THIS MATTERS: nothing in my career changed as much as the ninety seconds I spent working out how that door opened.

6 Have a pitch about who you are, not what you have done

This is the part that mattered, and it is the part people skip.

I had no case studies. No PM experience. No portfolio. What I had was a three-part explanation of myself, and I gave it almost the same way every time.

First, the hardest technical thing I owned. I work on the platform controller hub, which is how everything on a chip connects back to the CPU. Second, the unpaid evidence of the other half: on weekends I build Alexa skills in Java and some of them are live. Third, the conclusion those two facts force: I am not interested in being a hardware person or a software person. I want to be the PM who brings them together.

EXAMPLE

Write yours in that shape. One thing you are credibly deep in. One thing you do without being paid that proves the other side. One sentence that only makes sense if someone gives you the role you are asking for.

WHY THIS MATTERS: when you have no direct experience, the only honest thing you can offer is the shape of yourself. Done properly that is not a weakness, it is the argument.

7 Attach a number to yourself

The way I think about it now, everyone in a hiring conversation is a salesperson and the product is your effort. A company hires you because it believes you will return more than it pays.

If you can say I am a million dollar candidate and here is why, you are easier to hire, because you have done the arithmetic for the person who has to justify you.

EXAMPLE

Finish this sentence before any conversation: because of me, this team either makes or saves X. Use a real number from your current job even if it is small. The habit matters more than the size.

WHY THIS MATTERS: I could not point to PM experience, so I pointed at business impact instead, and that is the language the person in front of me already spoke.

8 What happened next, and how fast

The CVP said something I still remember. I don't really know what you're about, but I can tell you're passionate about the PM space. Talk to my recruiter.

I found the recruiter on LinkedIn and reached out. She called, asked what I did, what my experience was, and what I was interested in. About two weeks after the conference I was booked to fly out for the loop.

EXAMPLE

Reach out the same week, on the platform where the person actually is, and lead with the specific moment. Not "we met at the conference" but the thing you talked about.

WHY THIS MATTERS: the conversation buys you an introduction, and an introduction has a shelf life measured in days.

9 The honest caveat

It is a different year now and a lot has changed. I would not tell anyone that buying a conference ticket is a strategy, because the ticket did nothing. The twenty conversations did something, and the pitch did the rest.

If you take one thing from this, take the pitch structure, and then find any room at all where you can say it to someone who has hiring power.

EXAMPLE

The room does not have to be a conference. A meetup, an internal event, a community Slack, a mutual connection who will make one introduction.

WHY THIS MATTERS: I got lucky with the room. I was not lucky about what I said when I got there, and that is the part you can build before you need it.

Fifty applications and zero calls is not evidence that you are not good enough. It is evidence that the channel is broken, and almost everyone is standing in the same broken channel.

Go find a room. Work out the gate. Know exactly what you are, in three parts, before you walk in.